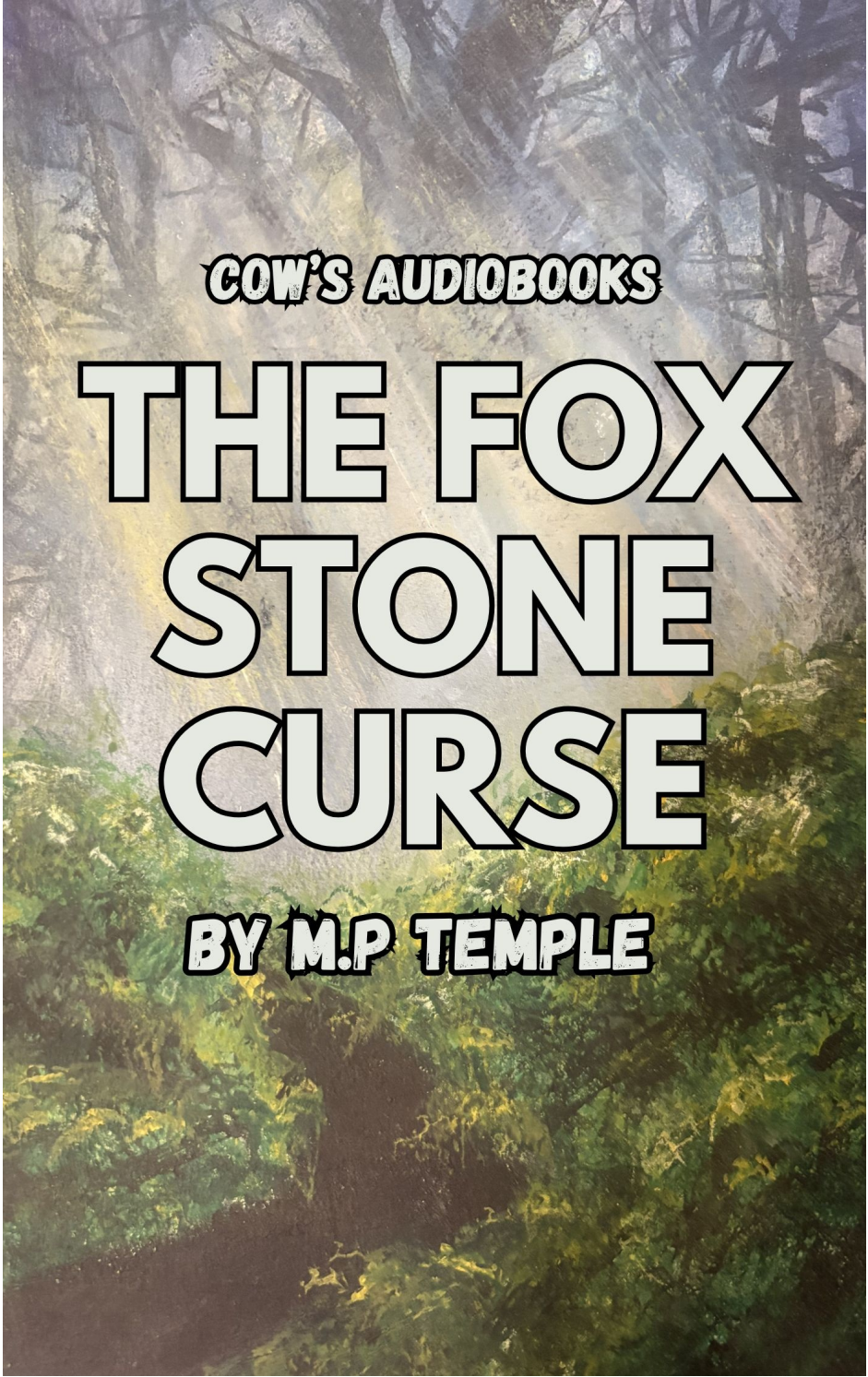




COW'S AUDIOBOOKS

THE FOX STONE CURSE

BY M.P. TEMPLE

Episode One: Orphan

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Siskiyou Mountains, Southern Oregon. October, 1846

“What were you all thinking?” The woman thought. Staring at the wagon full of wardian cases, packed full of flowers. Someone transporting plants this far away? It didn’t make any sense.

The woman at this point was used to seeing death .The sight of deceased pioneers had become something the woman slow became used to. At first the random objects such as dressers and farm equipment alongside the spoke wheel path appeared at the start of the Oregon Trail. Back in Independence Missouri the woman watched countless families set off for a better life in the west. She had seen most of those people again, though not alive. Especially those not part of a paid caravan.

But out where the woman was in this latest find was far from the old world. Far from the Applegate Trail and deep into a mountain range that blocks the path to the Oregon shoreline.

Here the cliffs are steep, and following the river proved difficult with the terrain and the amount of foliage. Including evergreens and redwoods that were so tall the traveller could not see the tops. Standing up from the forest's rocky floor looked to her like looking into an endless sea of trees reaching up. This part of why no one in their right minds should have been travelling in this time of winter.

Having been a lone traveller completing the journey on foot, the woman already knew she was not in her right mind. But she removed her gloves and checked each body for any signs of life. She found none. Each feeling as cold as the mountain air and snow around her.

After she checked the group's things for anything she could use in the rest of her journey to the Oregon coast. Other than some warm pants the woman stuffed in her travel bag, the family carried mostly plants and books. When the traveller opened a few of these books, she found their pages completely blank.

“These people must have been mad.” The woman said aloud.

She was about to leave, but something sticking out of the snow caught her eye. A stone charm in the shape of a fox head attached to a silver chain. When she drew it out of the snow, she found the charm was attached to something else. A large glass bottle with a cork. She wiped the glass to get a better look. Inside was an entire ecosystem of tiny flowers and bugs. Flowers of different sizes and colours.

“Transporting all this junk got you all killed,” The woman said. She had learned in order to survive anything one had to shed everything. She left knowing whoever the family was, their undoing was because they had to have everything. That sort of thinking made the woman fear the future of the West in the years to come. But now, her mind shifted back to finding the Illinois river where the next part of her journey could begin. Finding land and starting a new identity. In a place where no one would ever learn of what she had done back in the East.

She took the bottle and placed it in her backpack, along with a few of the blank books. Then she fastened the stone fox charm around her neck and set off into the unforgiving mountains.



Cave opening. Evening.

Not long after, a few hours of trekking through the forest, the woman choose to stop for the night when she came across a good spot. She searched for the driest wood she could find and found a place inside the cave to build a fire. Using the blank pages of the books, the kindling was lit. It took a long time for the fire to start, with how soaked everything was. The woman felt glad she had come across something dry to use.

She mixed up and threw the corn dodger batter in a pan of lard on top of the fire. It pop and sizzled as she examined the jar she had found. Each time she looked, she found a different kind of plant she had not noticed before. Stranger still, they did not look any plant she had ever seen. And she knew enough to know what foliage would get you through dinner and which would send you to the grave. One of the flowers looked like tiny blue sunflowers. This could not be, of course, since that colour is not natural to them.

“How are all these able to grow in there?” The woman wondered.

The charm was examined next. She could not read what was written on the back, it being some sort of East Asia text. While doing this, she noticed a crack on the fox's left ear. She tested the charm's strength by pressing her thumb and and index finger together.

It snapped. Something that looked almost spirit leapt out of the charm and into the fire. Sending the pan of corn dodgers clanging on the cavern floor. Black smoke escaped from the charm, filling the surrounding air. In a coughing fit, she dropped the charm and fled to find clearer air. When she did, she found a large white fox with red ears eyeing her.

“Can I get a ride to Kyoto?” The fox said. “That’s a joke where I come from.”

“What are you?” Asked the woman.

“I’m a lion. Roar.” The fox replied, laughing.

“I’d guess more like a snake.” The woman scuffed. “What do you want from me?”

“Do you not believe me? How about you tell me your name?”

“I’m not telling my name to a talking, lying fox.” She said.

At hearing this, the fox opened its wide jaws and breathed a blazing puff of fire. It growled and said, “It is not wise to insult me. I can take a joke. I can’t take disrespect.”

“I think I’m packing up. And getting as far away from you as I can.”

The fox smiled. “You can try if you’d like. But you have freed me from the stone. You’re my special little friend now. Aren’t you? I’ll be seeing you around. Everywhere you go. Until you put me back in.”

“If you set foot near me ever again, I will shoot you and skin you. Then wear your hide as a hat for the rest of my days.”

“I bet I’d make a lovely hat.” The fox said. “You will wish you never broke that charm soon enough. If you will excuse me, this forest would be easier to search without all the trees.”

The woman couldn’t even attempt to grab the fox if she wanted. Before she could react, it had fled the cave and escaped into the night. She began out after it, searching the snow for the creature’s tracks. But the snow was coming down too heavily to follow anything. She determined to keep looking for the creature. If the

thing was going to do as it said, she didn't want a fire that might bring people about.

But before she could go further into the steep, she heard something loud echoing from within the cavern.

“Is someone out there! Please!” It cried.

It was the voice of a teenager.



Deeper in the cave.

The child was curled up around a pack missing patches of leather. Not far from where water flowed into a rushing river. The woman could only find her through the clearing smoke because the girl had lit a lantern. Next to her was another bottle filled with stringy, vine-y plants.

The traveller found the sight of the skinny girl hard to bare. The girl struggled to put words together after using most of her strength to call for help. She looked to be only fourteen or fifteen years old. The same age the woman was when she fled.

“Are... you going to eat those laces?” The child asked. Pointing to the woman's boots.

The woman took another look at the girls' pack. "I was saving those for later. Get up. I'll try to cook you something edible."

But the girl was so weak that the woman had to carry her back to the travellers' campsite. There she made a single biscuit with lard, flour, water and salt. Along with a thin slice of boiled salt pork.

"You have to eat as slowly as you can." The woman told the child, handing over the plate.

The child could not pace herself and finished half the small biscuit almost in a single bite.

"What is your name?" The woman asked.

The girl did not look up from her food. She bit into the soft biscuit like a cougar ambushing a prairie chicken. "I don't remember my name." The child said. "More, please."

"No," The woman snapped. "That's enough. Until you get used to eating again. I'll cook up more for our journey to Oregon City. Where we can find someone to help you once you get well enough to walk."

The girl threw down her plate. "I am not going to Oregon City. I am going to the bay to camp Whisper. It's the

southern coastline. These plants must get there.”

“Our lives are more important than any plant.”

“No,” the girl said sternly. “We had come all this way. I am so close. I have to do what my family couldn’t. What my father wanted to do more than anything else. There are others waiting for these plants, and if they don’t get them, something bad is going to happen.”

“Worse than ending up dead in the mountains?” The woman said.

The girl burst into tears. The woman’s face did not change expression. “That’s hard to hear, but it’s the truth. You can regrow plants. You can’t regrow life.”

“You’re wrong. These can never be regrown. Some of these have been growing for hundreds of years.” The girl said, trying to stand up. The woman caught her as she fell the instant the girl put weight on her knee.

“If you want my help, you are going to Oregon City. And there’s nothing you can do to change my mind.”

The girl reached into the pack, frantically searching. She clutched a piece of paper and handed it to the woman. “You take me and the plants to Whisper, and you can have it.”

The woman examined the document carefully.

“You must really love flowers.” The woman said. “If this is real, you have yourself a deal. Before you get some rest and I get the fire hotter, do you know anything about a fox charm?”

The girl shook her head. “It could be one of my family’s things. They have... had. A lot of trinkets from overseas.”

“Nothing that talks?”

The girl took a long pause. She again shook her head.

“Get some sleep. We need to get moving as soon as we can. Somewhere I can hunt something. If this storm ever lets up. I didn’t plan to feed two people.”



Wilderness outside of cave. Two weeks later.

The colour had returned to the girl’s face slowly over the last few days. It took a week, but when the sun melted the snow, the girl began to walk again. A strength only gained by numerous small meals throughout the day.

But the traveller and she had hardly spoken. Truth be

told, there was no need to risk letting any sort of information about her past out into the open. The less anyone knew, the better.

She woke to the girl crying in her pile of clothes in the corner of the cavern. A sound that often troubled her when she didn't expect it.

“You want to talk about that squeaky wheel you got in your eyes?” She asked the girl.

There was no reply.

Upon that, she took the opportunity of the full moon to try her luck at night hunting. In a few hours the sun would rise in the mist, letting her find her way back to the camp. Though she had not seen deer or much of any game for weeks, she needed something. The rations were already starting to run low, and they had not yet crossed the mountain. There was no outpost for hundreds of miles in any direction. The only way was to push through the wilderness and find the river. Then hope the girl wasn't delusional and that there are in fact people somewhere on the coast.

The woman took the document from her coat pocket, looking it over before again hiding it away. Something seemed too good to be true.

There was a rustling in a bush across the way. A ground squirrel leapt out and sniffed around the rocks. Giving the woman a perfect shot. She unholstered her twenty-eight calibre Colt Paterson and lined up for the shot. Before she could squeeze the trigger, she felt something crawl up her and tickle her ear.

“Hello my special friend. Guess who has been looking for you? If you do as much as twitch, I will see how far my teeth can venture into your neck,” said the fox.

“Get off my shoulder.”

“I just got comfortable, thank you.” The fox said politely. “I decided not to burn everything down yet. Because I am looking for someone. I found the rest of who I was looking for, with my job completed for me already. But there is one girl who is unaccounted for. You wouldn’t happen to know anything about where she is. Would you?”

“You are not the type of folk I’d give a girl to. I’d rather give her to the mormon’s!”

The fox switched to sitting on her left shoulder. It dug its claws into the woman’s arms. “I’m starting to think you don’t know who I am. We aren’t sharing watermelon here. I am a messenger. And I have a message to deliver.”

“Yeah? I have a message for you too.”

The woman grabbed the fox and threw it to the ground. She fired her revolver three times at the fox. And all three times the bullets stopped at the tip of the fox’s coat and turned around and came hurling back at the woman. One bullet grazed her leg. The other lodged into her chest.

“Oh no. You shot me. I’m done for.” The fox made a loud, thunderous sound, sending flames flying from its mouth. “Now, back to why I am here. Stop dying for a moment and tell me. Where is the girl?”

The woman could not speak. She dropped the gun and heard its hammer crack when it hit the mountain’s rocky ground. She gasped, feeling like she suddenly had only half of her usual breath. The fox circled around her, at ease and sniffing at the air unfazed.

“If I see you alive ever again, then I know you were lying to me. For your sake, you better hope that this is the end for you. If I find out you are helping that little girl, and you have not turned her over to me? I’ll let you use your imagination. Now, one last time with feeling. You haven’t seen a girl starving anywhere?”

The woman was able to get the words out . “No. Girl.”

“Then I will let you get on with your little hunt of stringy tasting animals. As you were mortal.”

She could only watch as the fox gracefully strolled into the brush. The sun had begun to rise, giving her enough light to limp back towards the cave. Struggling to take each breath. While this wasn't the first time she had been shot, nothing she had ever felt compared to that.



Cave

Through her gargling and struggling breath, the woman was able to tell the girl, “I'd like to die over here.” Pointing to a spot along the cavern wall. The girl helped the wounded traveller to rest, with a panicked look in her eyes.

“You can't.” The girl said. “We have to get my family's garden to the bay.”

“I don't... have much say, do I?” the woman struggled to say.

“We need to get out of here.” The girl said. “As soon as we can.”

The woman, still fighting for every breath she took, simply motioned to the large hole in her chest. “I think... I’m staying... here. Forever.”

The girl took the garden jar from her pack and uncorked it. With tweezers, she plucked a large blade of miniaturised Mosquito Grass.

“Felt like tending to the flowers as I lay here dying?”

The girl showed her the single blade of grass. “It’s like a wand. I’m going to get the bullet out.”

“The hell you are.” The woman said. Trying to raise her voice only to find that she could not. Here she was in her last moments and the kid was playing make believe. Possibly from a state of delusion brought on by the side effects of malnutrition. She knew it was hopeless not only for her, but for such a weak girl.

The weak girl pointed the blade of grass towards the woman’s wounds. “Minadijobu.” She chanted.

They both waited for something to happen. Which nothing did.

“I’m sorry. I’m a beginner.” The girl said.

“After I meet my end. Get as far from here as you can. A

fox is hunting you.”

Before she could reply, a crow swooped into the small cavern opening. Its black feathers were covered in snow, and its beak looked longer than an average bird's. The creature skipped over to the woman and leapt on top of her chest wound.

“It worked!” The girl exclaimed.

The bird carefully examined the damage. Suddenly, with a precise peck with its beak entered the wound. With a jerk of its head, the bullet clanked on the stone floor. From the darkness behind them, leading further into the cave, appeared a host of fireflies. But the woman could feel heat around her when they swarmed. Dozens crawled inside and begin to explode. Cauterising the damage in her lungs.

The woman suddenly gasped for air, being able to fully breathe. Though not without a tremendous amount of pain.

“Thank you for answering my call.” The girl said to the crow.

The crow cawed back at her, picked up the bullet in its beak and flew away.

“We have to go. Now!” said the girl. “Before the fox....”

“What does the fox say?” A voice said from the cave opening.

The fox god’s claws clanked on the stone ground, and it drew closer to the woman and the girl. It sniffed the air around, then nodded.

“Yup. Smells like forbidden Galdorian magic to me. Hello, Bonnie Snufferclyde. I haven’t seen you since you were a toddler. You know what I am here for.”

“Not today.”

Bonnie pointed her grass wand at the ceiling above the fox. She shouted. “Blahbertgileous!”

A bright beam shot out of the grass, causing the cavern entrance to collapse. Sending large rock boulders on top of the fox.

Bonnie repeated the spell over and over until it was certain that the path to them was obstructive. Leaving them in darkness. The fireflies returned, long enough for the girl to dish out a small stick from her pack. After whispering something, she touched grass wand to the stick. It began to glow. Illuminating their way.

“Great. Now we die in the cave.” The woman said.



Further in the cavern

“I thought you couldn’t remember your name.” The woman asked the child, or Bonnie, rather.

“That was true,” she said. “At first. Then I didn’t want you to know who I was. A lot of people hate my family. Because of the things we grow. No one is supposed to know about any of this. I had no choice but to help you. The rest of my family is depending on me.”

“What are you?” Asked the woman. “You need to be honest before I get any more lead in me. Are you some kind of witch?”

“No,” Bonnie said sternly. “Galdorians. We are more like. Garden Wizards. Our powers come from magic plants we grow that we tap into using vegetables or anything with roots.”

“Why is a god trying to murder you? Because they don’t like your tulips? Why was it trapped in a charm?”

“Don’t insult my tulips,” Bonnie sneered. “I’ve won best

in show many times. I know how to grow them. Using them. Has been hit or miss. My father never got to teach me more. My family caught the fox and trapped its soul in the stone. It's been in there for ages."

"Well, thanks for ticking it off," the woman said. "Is there anything else I need to know while I limp to your coastal city? I already can't trust you."

"Telling a Whitlock, I mean. A non magic user, about our practices, will anger a lot of the other villagers. You have to trust me. These people are ruthless in keeping our world secret. I couldn't have told you before."

"There's something you don't seem to be understanding." The woman said as the two walked deeper into the cavern. "We are the only ones out here for hundreds of miles. Death is waiting at both our doors. We can't keep things if we are travelling together. And we can not let that fox keep running loose."

"I don't know how to use a soul binding Orchid. My dad knew. All my dad's journals are back at the camp where... they died."

"The books were blank." The woman said.

"To you. Yes. Only other Galdorian's can read the ink. If

we can get back there, we can learn how to...”

“There’s no going back. That fox is going to be patrolling this area. You need to get across the mountain to where we are going, get help and come back. As for me you can keep your land. Nothing is worth this.”

Bonnie shook her head. “You don’t understand. This is a god we are talking about. Having more of us isn’t going to help us at all. We need to find another way.”

“This isn’t what I signed up for.” Scuffed the woman.

“The land I am giving you is on the shore itself. This is worth it. You just have to help me. I’ll deal with the fox. I will include the land claims of all of my deceased family members.”

“This deed is for land on the beach?” The woman asked.

“Yes. If we have to be honest with each other, then how about you tell me your name?”

“You need my help that badly?”

“Yes,” the girl said desperately.

“Shut off that light.” The woman commanded. “The fox can smell it. It’s only a matter of time before it gets through the rocks and shows up behind us. We need to

find another light source. And. My name. Is. Almira. You don't need to know my last name."

"Hello. Almira." The girl said. "I'm Bonnie."

Episode Two: Wanderer

Days Later. Six miles deep within the Siskiyou Mountains.

Almira drew two cards and tried to hide her disgust. The fire was down to hot coals that lit the cavern room. It's light reflecting off the crystal formations that towered above. They had found a trickle of water hours earlier and had stopped to rest and for a poor ration of food. Now they listened to the dripping sounds echoing throughout the cavern. Every once in a while, feeling a gush of fresh air from a crack in the ground nearby.

"You calling or what?" Bonnie asked, flipping through her hand of cards.

"I'll raise a biscuit." Almira flicked the overcook bread towards the pot.

Bonnie nodded, pushing her own leftovers to call the bet. Immediately afterwards, she flipped over her cards.

"Full house."

Almira threw down her cards. "If I had my gun, I'd shoot you for cheating. You did something magic to the deck."

“They are your cards,” Bonnie took everything in the winning pot and smiled. “You are really bad at poker.”

“I’ve won my share at the gambling halls. You told me you’d never played.”

“Yeah, and you believed it,” Bonnie shrugged. “And since when do they let women bet? The men I’ve met on the trail would have laughed at you so hard that you would have gone home in embarrassment.”

“How did you do it? What spell did you cast?”

Bonnie took a bite of the biscuit and shook her head. “I played cards with the other wagon train kids. Who I couldn’t use magic on because no one is supposed to know our powers exist.”

“Says who?”

“Our village, that is who. Galdorian’s who have come before us. We are the chosen people. The rest of the world can’t handle the magic that we grow.”

“You know what about you I can’t handle?” Almira said. “How high a stack of cow pies you got lying here. You made some sort of tea from a plant in your jar right before the game. Something green. What witchcraft is that?”

Bonnie began to pack up the camp. “Green tea. You lost to a kid sipping on green tea. You lost fair and square.”

“Well, if you all were as good at travelling as you are at cards, you and your family would be fishing on the coast right now,” Almira grumbled.

The girl froze. “How awful a person do you have to be to say that?”

“Folk’s don’t call me sunshine. I’m kind of awful person who speaks the truth. You all couldn’t even think of eating the plants to stay alive.”

Bonnie narrowed her brows. “Not only can we not do that, most magic plants are toxic. It takes a skilled herbalist to find the leaves and roots that can be consumed. Why are you speaking so horribly to me? My family tamed the Appalachian wilderness. We fought hard with generations of knowledge to stay alive. We failed.”

“Trying hard doesn’t help much out here.”

“Remember that yourself. Cause we are being chased by a god. One that put a bullet through your chest.”

“Only ‘cause your family was carrying around a bunch of useless junk. Fine. You didn’t cheat. And maybe you were of some help. But not enough. I’ll be surprised if either

of us makes it to the coast. All that baggage is going to be the end of you, like it was them.” Almira said.

Something began to echo loudly. The rushing of water.

“The snow must be melting outside.” Almira said, gathering what she could. “The only exit out is that crack. We are going to have to hope it leads back up to somewhere dry.”

“We can’t go down now, not if there is a flood coming.”

“Did you see how much snow was outside before you destroyed the cave entrance? We can’t wait out that much rain without drowning. Get in the hole. Quick.”

The last sounds they heard as they crawled into the crack were the sizzling of the coals. Being put out by a slow water current that swept through the room.



Underground River

The water level in the tight tunnels started to rise. Almira found it harder to drag her pack with her back foot as she crawled through the rocks. The further the two went, the more narrow the passage seemed to

become. They struggled to see well enough with Bonnie holding the lamp from behind Almira.

“Stop!” Almira cried out. “Dead end. Go back.”

“I can’t turn around. How am I...”

Almira interrupted. “Time to learn to crawl backwards as fast as you can. We’ll try the left path back in the room we came from.”

“It’s hard to move with all the water pushing on me,” Bonnie shouted.

“Keep at it.”

Both of them paused. They felt a breeze of earthy smelling air crash through the passage. The sound of gushing water came from behind them.

Almira looked hard at the stone wall in front of her. In total defeat.

“You got any more of that magic?” Almira asked.

“I can’t get to my pack behind me.”

“Leave the pack. Get rid of everything you have.”

“NO!” Bonnie shouted. “I won’t leave my family’s spell garden!”

The surrounding stones shook. A thunderous cracking sound rang out. They could only listen as they heard something begin to break away.

“Any last words?” Bonnie asked, choking on the incoming water. “Anything you need to say before you meet Jesus, or whatever you believe?”

“I’ll say what I got to say if you say what you got to say first.”

“Okay,” Bonnie said. “Maybe some of the magic plants we were selling shouldn’t have been sold. Think dark, messed up stuff. The fox isn’t after us for no reason. We deserve this.”

“I still think you cheated at cards.” Almira said as the shaking intensified. She fought to keep her head above the flood, but soon it would be impossible. “And I did something wrong too. I killed a man. With his own service revolver. I...”

The water took her. They both struggled to do anything they could. But there was no use.

Suddenly, the passage cracked ahead of them at the dead end. It crumbled, exposing another room above. Almira saw some kind of light through the water. She swam

towards it, her pack still attached to her foot. She gasped when reached fresh air. When she had stopped coughing and pulled herself up to dry ground, she noticed the moon shining. A thick forest was around her, one that sat in the caverns still but in a sinkhole with open night skies above.

“We got lucky.” Almira said, still trying to catch her breath. “We were almost goners... Bonnie?”

There was no reply.

“Bonnie!” Almira called again. She had not had come to the surface. It hit her that the girl was still trapped in the flood below. Still trying to bring her pack with her.

“Dang it. I knew she wasn’t going to make it.” Almira cursed. She had done all she could. Going back into a collapsing, flooded tunnel without a light source would be impossible.

Another impossible thought came to her mind. Defeating a fox god alone as a mortal. She turned back towards the water, which formed a pool in the cavern above.

“Hold on kid.”

She took off her shoes and dived into the pool, swimming back into the tunnel.



Sink Hole

The woman did not remember how she got back onto the forest floor. Nor did she understand why Bonnie was pounding on her chest, screaming.

“Breathe!” she cried.

Water spewed from Almira’s lungs and mouth. She sat up, gasping for air.

“I jumped in for you. How did I get here?” Almira asked.

“You found me in the dark and brought me back. But my pack caught us and you started to drown. I could I cut it off.”

“All your family’s botany?”

“All the spells I grew with my mother and grandmother are gone. Forever.”

“What about the jar I took?” Almira said. “Check my pack. It was small enough that I thought I could get a few bucks out of it.”

Bonnie did what she asked. But she found shards of glass

and plants scattered throughout. The jar had broken when the sinkhole pool gave in.

“You really cut it?” Almira asked.

Bonnie nodded. “You were right. We shouldn’t have made it this far carrying everything. The only way is to leave everything behind. Like you.”

Almira, regaining her strength, lifted one of the plants to get a better look. “We can try to replant everything in this jar in the forest soil. Maybe something will live on.”

“They can’t grow here. There’s no hope for the family legacy now. It died with that portable garden.”

After a few minutes, all the plants had grown up to five times larger. Almira gently planted as many as she could, while Bonnie sat. Lost in disappointment.

“While the garden might be gone.” Almira said while examining the last vine. “What they taught you in still there. If they learned how to cultivate magic so well, it ticked off the gods, you’ll find a way too.”

“Who did you kill?” Bonnie asked. “Is that way you are out here? To find a place to hide out so you don’t get dragged back to some courthouse and hung?”

“Pretty sure this is a nightshade.” Almira dug a hole regardless.

“That’s for soul bonding.” Bonnie replied. “Of course, it’s a nightshade. I could have trapped the fox with that. We have to find help in the new village. To get a group to the camp to save what they can. At least now I won’t be tempted to use magic. Cause all my powers are gone.”

“We’ve almost made it to the other side of the mountain. On foot, the rest of the way is not far. You’ll have to pretend to be a Whitlock or whatever nasty word you were calling me.”

“Please tell me your pack stayed dry.”

“No,” Almira showed the bag to her. “Dirt, water. All the food I had left. We better hope it doesn’t start...”

Before the words “start snowing” could be said, Almira felt something cold land on her forehead.

“Do you think we will make it to the village?”

“Not a chance in hell.”



November, West side of Siskiyou Mountains.

The snow returned heavier than it had been before. Replacing all the snow that had melted and entered the caves. They travelled hours in whiteout conditions, moving slower than a bottle being filled with molasses.

“We can’t keep going like this. I can’t feel my face.” Bonnie shouted.

“Trying to build a shelter with two pocket knives isn’t going to work out how you might think it would,” Almira shouted back. “All the wood is soaked through. A fire would be useless. The only way is to push through,”

“For how long? Are we even close to the shore?” Bonnie stopped a moment to pant. “The snow feels like it’s getting heavier every hour.”

“No one has ever been here. Much less, you don’t know where the village is for sure. Except all those people living here long before the colonies.”

“I’ll find it. I’ll get us out of this,” Bonnie started walking again.

“Fear not. We have my boot laces still. Aren’t you glad we saved those?”

“Better than bone marrow and disintegrated ox femur!”

“Hold.” She paused and lifted her nose to the air. “Do you smell that?”

“Lie to me.” Bonnie covered her face with her eyes. “Tell me that you are not overwhelmed by the smell of burning pine.”

“What are you talking about? That’s the scent of johnnycakes if I’ve ever smelled them.”

“Really? That isn’t the forest burning around us?”

“You asked me to lie, I never said I was good at it. If I had to wager, I’d guess the world has gone up in flames around us.”

Bonnie dropped into the snow. “Okay. This is a good place to die, I think. We can’t escape that.”

“Get up. You’re folding on a royal flush. Look.”

A large red and orange glow illuminated through the white haze. Through it, a bonfire could be seen. As soon as they began to hear the cracking of the burning pine logs, they spotted a cabin.

“Don’t give me gambling advice,” Bonnie said.

“Look at what’s hanging around the flames.” Almira pointed. “Fox hides. I didn’t think there were any traders in these parts. Is this one of your villagers?”

“No,” Bonnie said, inspecting the tanning work. “This is not Galdorian. This is a master crafter.”

“Do I want to know why your family knows how to skin hides?”

“I told you that some spells require some pretty messed up stuff. Do you think there is someone inside the cabin?”

The two opened the door and entered the warm cabin. Smelling heavily of something cherry scented. A single candle flicked while a pot of rice was boiling over the floor stove. The sight of food caused both of their mouths to water.

“We should wait til whoever made it gets back. Maybe see if we can get some of those eggs and chicken wing tips.” Almira said.

Bonnie grabbed the nearest bowl. “So stealing food is where you draw the line morally? Killing is fine. But eating? To hell you go!”

“...eat the damn rice, kid.”

Neither of them got far into their meals before they heard a gun cock from the cabin door. Realising that someone had returned, they put down the bowls and lifted their hands over the heads.

“We’re just hungry.” Bonnie pleaded.

The large man stood holding his pistol. He wore clothing made of thick fox fur. The man looked more muscle than human. Yet something about his eyes felt off to Almira.

He put his gun down, then with his left hand pointed to a basket near other food and supplies. “Don’t touch my eggs.”



Cabin

[Crack of a block of wood being chopped.]

“Keep chopping til you pay for the rice you ate. That was the lord’s rice, you know.” The man said. He stood watching Almira like a hawk. Making sure the wood was being spilt evenly.

“So you have no fear of trapping a god fox. You are sure you are that good,” Almira said, slicing another piece of pine in half. He crossed his arms and scoffed.

“My God is great. It is to be as easy as making cornbread. I tell you if you would read that Book of Mormon, you’d know that too,” he said. “There is no place for a girl. You know this. Let me take her with me. To take her some place where she can get the help she deserves.”

“I can’t. I have an agreement with the child.”

“That you’ll be with the girl until you reach where ever she was going? How is that going for you so far?” The man chuckled.

“If this snow ever lets up, our agreement is obtainable. I can see that the girl finds a family once we find the village.”

“Stop chopping. Come here.” Almira did as he asked. “You need to think long and hard about this. Sally was her name, you said? Are you the kind of person who should be raising a child? A role model who can set them off in the right direction. Heck, are you even a person who should be around kids?”

“I can’t leave her now,” Almira put her hands in her coat pockets, to help bring back the feeling in her fingers.

“Why? You pretending you had a good childhood by trying to boss some kid around? Could you live with yourself if

your foolhardy gets her killed? Are you even sure there is fertile soil wherever she is going? What if you get there and the land is salted from the ocean? You have to see how foolish this agreement is you have going on here.”

Almira turned to the cabin, deep in thought. The kid would be better off near a proper town with real supplies. A chance to be around other kids and without someone who knew something about rearing. She had already lost her family’s plants. What was the point of taking her now?

“Do you care about her?” He went on.

“Yes.”

“Then you know what you should do.”

Almira examined her knife.

“You’re right. I lived this long by shedding everything. I can’t take on a kid. I know that kids that age should have it better than I had. You’ll take her? No funny business?”

“I swear by the Mormon she will not be harmed,” the man said.

“You have kept your word so far. And shared your food and warmth. I reckon you should have harmed us by now

if you wanted. Okay. Help me trap the fox. Then take her to Oregon City so she can learn to live a better life.”

“Pinky swear it will be done,” the man said, winking.



Canyon River

“Foxes keep caches of food around.” The man in the fox coat said. “Chances are he has a stash here somewhere. I’ve set up a trio of snares. That fox will come around soon enough.”

“This isn’t going to work, a god will not fall for this,” Bonnie said in protest.

“Don’t criticise a professional,” the man said.

“I’d like to talk to Mary Sue. Alone,” Bonnie told the man.

“You should tell her.” He said, nodding. He retreated from the river, back further into the snow-packed wilderness.

“Something is not right here,” Bonnie crossed her arms. “I don’t think we should stay here. We should take our chances keeping on west.”

Almira lowered her head. “You will do no such thing. I’ve talked it over with Kit. The Mormon is to take you to Oregon City. Where you can find real help? What you do from there is your own doing.”

“How could you?” Bonnie yelled. “We’ve made it this far, I promised you land, I paid you!”

“You can have it back.” Almira tried to hand her the document. Bonnie wouldn’t take it. “I didn’t make this decision half hearted. This is what is best. You’ve almost lost your life twice on my watch. And truth be told? When you didn’t swim up from that pool in the sinkhole, I decided that I want you to have the life I couldn’t have. I can’t protect you. Take the papers back.”

“No,” Bonnie said with a sigh. “Keep it. I. Hate it. But I understand. I can always come back. Keep the land, with the agreement that you must come visit me again. Someday. You saved me.”

“I’m sorry it has to be this way,” Almira said, still holding out the papers for her. But when Bonnie refused again, she placed them back in her coat. “I wish I could be stronger for you.”

A loud yell came from one of the snares. A sound so powerful that it made the women cover their ears. Jim

the Mormon, however, did not. He barely moved through all the commotion. The fox god had been caught in the trap. He struggled with a wire around its neck to escape, but he could not slip through.

“That snare was blessed with holy water,” the man in the fox coat said. “No chance it’s going anywhere. You should keep heading out Mary Sue. While the sun will light your way. I’ll take care of the girl.”

“I hate that you did this to me,” Bonnie said.

Almira stuck out her hand. “I do, too. You’re going to be okay. You’ll see me someday. I’ll find a way back to your family’s books and will save what I can. The village will know what has happened. It’s a promise.”

The girl pushed aside her hand and hugged her tighter than Almira had even been hugged in her life. Doubt crept in.

“Thank you. For everything.” She said. “And take this. My grass wand. For good luck.”

“I can’t use your magic.” The woman said.

“Say “Blahbertgilleouis” if anything ever goes wrong. If you’re going to die anyway you might as well have fun saying the death curse.”

Almira took the grass wand. “I’m not saying that. I’ll miss you, kid.”

The man spoke up. “Best get moving. The fox will struggle till the fight is out of him.”

Almira let go. The girl slowly walked over to the man, who wore a wide smile on his face.

The man replied, but not with his voice. Instead, she heard another familiar fox speak. “You made the right choice. My special friend”.

“Come back.” Almira commanded at once.

But it was too late. The fox god in the snare exploded, as if filled with a multitude of fireworks. Its sparks shot out up and across the river and into the sky through the clearing in the trees. Words appeared in the sky, repeating the same words over and over: “Ha ha”. The man in the fox coat disappeared in front of their eyes. In its place, the fox god appeared.

Vines grew from the ground and attached themselves to Bonnie’s arms. She cried out.

“Got you,” the fox said. “You are going to show me, Bonnie, where the forbidden plants are. Then you know what your end will be.”

Bonnie struggled in her chains frantically. “Never! Just because the magic gods don’t like how we do magic doesn’t mean we are doing anything wrong!”

“If I gave you a knife as a present and you’re using it to stab people, I think I have the right to take it back. Your opinions are futile.”

Almira charged towards the fox. “Let her go! Take me instead.” But her feet froze in the snow, rendering her completely stuck.

“You want to hear a story?” The fox asked. “It’s gotta punch line. There once was a lazy man who refused to work. His friends grew worried that he couldn’t support himself, but one of friends knew of a perfect job. A travelling circus had been going around advertising to all who would hear about the animal exhibits. But you see, the circus tiger had died. And there were people paying see it. So the friend proposed that the lazy man take a job at the circus as a tiger replacement. Wearing its skin as a costume. He would act like a cat all day and entertain the people. Best of all, he could nap all day if he wanted to. And he would make fifty dollars a day. The man got excited at this and went to the circus right away. They hired him on the spot and gave him the tiger fur to wear. For a long while the man was in heaven,

having found the job of his dreams. Until he heard, ‘Gather around, everyone, for the main event! This savage tiger will fight a mighty brown bear!’ The man freaked out and pleaded for his life. ‘I’ve learned my lesson! I’ll work hard every day! I never again will be lazy!’ A door was opened, and a mighty bear approached the crying man. Suddenly, the bear whispered. ‘Stop crying, I’m also making fifty dollars a day.’”

The fox paused for laughter. There was none.

“Tough crowd.” The fox shrugged. “Perhaps you would prefer the dark and gritty ending of that joke. Here’s a bear. And I’m not paying you fifty dollars.”

The fox made a large, distressing bark. Something from the forest made its way towards Almira along the river’s shore.

[Bear yell]

“There is my brown bear!” The fox said. “Though he’s not being paid five dollars a day. Have fun.”

The fox used its teeth to drag the chains and Bonnie away. Almira could only watch as the bear charged at her. The creature struck her with its claws. Freeing her from the ice, but left deep cuts on her side. She tried to

use her pocket knife to slow the bear's attacks, but the blade seeming did little. Instead, she struck its nose with her fist as hard as she could. Then she dropped to the ground, covering her head.

This caused the bear to flee. But she had seen enough of the trail to know that he would be back. She tried to walk, but the pain from both her still hurting lungs and fresh cuts slowed her tremendously. Worst of all, she doubted the bear would remain gone. It would catch her scent again and track her.

Instead of leaving, Almira followed the fox and chain tracks.

Episode Three: Warrior

Siskiyou Mountains.

The snowy breeze passed through the claw marks on her shirt and into the open cuts. Causing intense pain. But she could not stop. She had tracked the fox's footprints back over the mountain. The fox was taking the girl back towards where they had first met. He had been forcing Bonnie to lead him back to where they had planted the remains of the plants in the broken jar. But why had she not simply turned back and gone the way they had come? Bonnie wasn't clever enough to out trick a fox. It meant that despite her wounds and struggles still with breathing, she had to keep on their track.

Almira held the trees around her for support as she walked with one hand. With the other, she held her side and tried to breathe through the pain the best she could. But as hard as she tried, her pace kept slowing the longer she travelled.

After many hours, she relented to pause on the trail to try to recover any strength she could. But right when she

chose to stop, there came a cracking sound from under her feet. The ground crumbled, sending her hurling into a pit. A pit that had been covered with hide and snow. She hit the bottom with a smack. The fall had not been deep enough to break any bones, but it did not matter. When she looked up at the opening where she had fallen, she knew she could not climb up. If only she had kept some of the rope or climbing axes, she once had on the trail. She had sold after passing the Rocky Mountains to a trading post in exchange for some horseshoes. Which in the end was a poor trade, since the horse died three weeks later trying to forge the Platte River.

She tried to climb out anyway, but the pain in her side stopped her. She cried out. Knowing it was no use. That's when she noticed the painting on the pit wall. It was a smiling fox.

In a panic, she emptied her pack. Looking for anything she could use to scale back up to the surface. She had nothing. Just the books she had transported from the death camp and odds and ends of food gone bad from water damage.

In anger she rose, grabbed a book and hit the taunting fox painting. She panted, kneeling facing the ground. In a long moment, she recollected all the memories she had

left behind. They had all led her to her doom.

“I’m still glad I killed him,” she said with a firm nod.

That’s when something caught her attention. Something softly glowed on the cover of the book. She had seen nothing written in the books before. But now there were words written in blank ink. With some sort of reflective glitter within it. Almira could now read the title of the book. ‘The Snufferclyde Book of Death Plants. Volume twelve’.

She flipped through the pages that were still dry. As if some waterproof protected spell. Finding detailed notes and drawings. With instructions on what words to say to connect to the plant to cast the spell when holding a vegetable gar. A gar called a wand in more modern terms. The other books were also volumes of the same series. Each detailing an exhausting number of different species that can be bred and how each plant can be used.

“I thought only Galdorians could read these,” Almira said. “I’m no wizard. This must be one of the foxes tricks. Unless there’s no such thing as the chosen ones. Shocker.”

But why? What purpose would that bring? Maybe when she had planted the magic into the soil, it bonded with

her somehow. Giving the ability to read the text. But if that were the case, that would mean there are no chosen ones.

Frantically, she started reading everything she could. If she were to find a way out of the pit, the answer would be there. If it were a fox's illusion, or if something changed the moment she planted the remains of the jar in the sinkhole earth.



The Pit. Hours Later.

While Almira's formal education had ended at the age of fourteen, she was not illiterate. Every word of the Snufferclyde book of death plants, volume 12, was recognisable to her. But nothing on any of the pages made any sense. For example, the rotting rose plant section was ten pages long. Its power could grant a caster the ability to fertile their garden with a person. She had read a quarter of the book but still had no idea how she could use any of it to get out of the pit. Much less what any of it meant. If she could even use it. If it were even real.

While down in the pit, reading through all the books she had collected, she couldn't help but wonder if she were in an illusion. If she were, this fox's knowledge was so vast it passes any possible comprehension.

She couldn't read any more. None of the information helped her in any way. Instead, she flipped back to a plant she had spotted earlier. The Claudius flower. A mature plant produces a spell that allows the gar caster to physically summon the dead for a brief amount of time. But with a cost of more than just the plant, the book warns the experience might be worse than expected.

Almira remembered planting a Claudius flower back in the sinkhole. This was a risk she felt like taking. She had been around the dead for many years now. There couldn't be anything years of a hardened pioneer couldn't handle. The trouble was finding out how to set the effect of the spell into effect. She remembered the girl would utter words, almost a chant. This was not detailed in the volumes that she had with her. Nor could she find the plant that Bonnie had used to summon the animals to help her after she had been shot.

Absolutely clueless and out of options, Almira pointed her grass gar in front of her. With her other hand, she read

the entire section about the Claudius flower. Hoping something she said would activate the plant. She did this until she could no longer speak and could no longer keep her eyes open.

When she next opened them, she saw someone standing in the pit in front of her. A man she had not seen in years. One that she knew with certainty was not among the living. There was a hole in his forehead. Almira looked at it like she were looking through a keyhole.

“You have some nerve to call upon me,” the man said. His moustache so long it seemed to dance as he spoke.

“This must be that white light I’ve heard about,” Almira said, leaning against the wall, struggling to hold herself up. “I didn’t figure you’d be here at the end. Should have guessed it. You here for revenge?”

“I’m here because you called me. My little murdering sugar pea.” The man said. “How have things been since you shot me?”

“Peachy.”

“Did you get everything you wanted? Or did you lose everything? This life you wanted without me,” he asked.

“This is my life. I didn’t want to share it with the likes of

you. You refused.”

“Your family and I had an agreement.” He said. “Tell me why you think I would help you when you call now?”

“This is a fever dream,” Almira told herself. Standing up again to attempt to scale the pit again.

“Try as you may, you’ll never be anything without me.” He said, watching her fall down every time she tried to take hold of the wall. “You might have made it all this way. But you are still a pathetic, spoiled little girl. Unable to have a normal life. You deserve to have nothing!”

“That’s what I used to think,” Almira said. “But I’m starting to believe you were wrong. Are you going to help me, ‘husband’, or not?”

“No,” the man said. “I am going to stay here as long as I can and watch you suffer.”

“That’s what you did when you were alive, I shouldn’t expect anything less. I learned from you. I learned that no one should have to live like that, and I’m not going to let that girl die,” she said, double-checking that the books were still packed.

“You couldn’t even make it through an entire night of

marriage,” the man said.

Almira held her pack tighter. “I was fourteen.”

She struck the man with the pack, sending him kneeling from the blow. She leapt on top of the man and used his back as a springboard up the pit. Her legs were stronger than her arms, and she was able to reach the ledge. But the man began to pull her back down. With a swift kick to his head, she climbed out and began to push snow down into the pit.

Then she stopped. She felt an object pressed against her back.

“Hand over any gar or wand you have. Then put your hands in the air and stand up.” The man behind her said. “By order of the Whisper Society, you are under arrest for performing dark magic.”



Sundown.

“We need to turn back. There’s a girl in danger. She is one of your villagers, you have to know this. The rest of her family was lost in the snowfall. Why else would you be here?” Almira shouted.

The vines around her wrists felt as heavy as steel shackles. But the man in red kept her marching until they came to a clearing. Through the snow on a tall wooded peak, they could see the ocean.

“Which child?” The man finally asked. The man who identified himself as J.K Diecknine.

She told him.

The man’s eyes shifted down. He touched the brim of his hat and shook his head. “Of course it’s the Snuffercylde. I will send the others to look for her. You can’t be trusted alone, you demon.”

“I’m not one of you. I only learned of this magic days ago.” Amira pleaded.

“Where did you learn this from?”

Almira grew quiet. She briefly glanced at her pack, containing the Snufferclyde volumes. She couldn’t give the man any reason to search her further.

“I found the plant.”

The man jabbed his carrot gar into her back. “Your lies are so thin anyone can see through them. Only the chosen Galdorians know how to weld this power. It takes

decades of hard work and learning. Whitlocks are too pathetic to do anything. From what I saw you cast in that pit, you are a master of plant magic. What you say is impossible. What you are hiding.”

“If we leave now, that girl is never coming home. You can’t do this to her.”

“The girl might be better off not being found. If I bring back to the village, she will take your side on the stake across from you. With the town watching you burn.”

“Then let us end in those flames. Not in this wilderness. Not her caught by that fox.”

The man stopped and turned Almira towards him. “Why did you not tell me she was being chased by a fox? That is a god messenger who must be treated with the utmost respect. Where is he?”

“That is who I was tracking. Before I got attacked by the...” Almira didn’t get to finish her sentence.

[Bear roar]

From behind nearby redwoods, the bear appeared. It charged at them. Almira pushed the man in front of the rampaging bear. The impact threw J.K like a rag doll. Dumping his bag, sending dried flowers and roots

everywhere. The bear, while violently clawing at him, did not stay near him. Instead, it tracked Almira who had fled to a distance. It charged.

Almira grabbed as many flowers and roots as she could as it ran. When the bear arrived, she tried to punch it in the nose and shove the magic plants into its mouth. This caught the creature off guard, and it was forced to swallow everything in its mouth.

The beast gave out a loud roar and grew double in size. Its eyes turned red and cloudy.

“Don’t do that, use the death spell!” Diecknine commanded her, unable to stand himself up.

“I don’t know how! You do it!” She shouted.

“I do not believe in using that kind of magic! It’s ‘Blahbertgillious’!” Diecknine screamed.

Almira pointed her grass wand at the bear and spoke: “Blabertdillouis?”

Diecknine screamed. “No!!!”

The earth shook. Snow flew everywhere. A rumbling began to echo in the mountain passes. A stream of boiling water shot up in front of the charging bear,

sending it soaring through the air. Scorching its skin. The water travelling into the sky before falling back down again. Cooling, landing as rain that coated the massive avalanche that was forming around them.

Almira grabbed onto the nearest redwood and held on for dear life as the rushing snow fell around her. The bear and Diecknine were swept down the mountain, as if being washed away in a sea of snow.

Diecknine's pack had caught in a nearby tree. She waited until the blast had finished at the bottom. The newly formed geyser did not stop. It kept sending boiling water rocketing into the sky.

Almira put the grass wand in her gun holster. "Okay. Don't use that one." She watched as the ice on the snow grew thicker and thicker by the minute.

In the distance came a familiar laughter. The one of a fox god.

"That way," Almira told herself. She gathered Diecknine's pack and escaped in the now foggy frozen forest.



West Side of the Mountains.

“Oh, you’re still here,” said the fox to Almira. He was dragging a long vine tied around Bonnie. The place they had been before now had several more inches of snow, now in a top layer of ice.

The woman slowly approached them, with her grass wand drawn.

“Cute wand, Whitlock,” the fox said sarcastically. “Please don’t tickle me. How dare you?”

“The girl is coming back with me. And that’s final,” Almira demanded.

The fox tilted his head upon hearing this. “Aren’t you a overly confident little peach baby? The Snufferclyde collection will be destroyed. Bonnie will take her punishment. That’s how this is going to happen. You wanna fill me in on where the plants are? Or do I call the bear over?”

Bonnie spoke up. “Leave Almira. You’ve had no hand in any of our misdeeds. Be gone and be rid of me.”

“We have a verbal agreement,” Almira said, drawing closer. The fox’s claws came out for her to see.

“We ended that. Save yourself.”

“That’s what I’m doing.” Almira said. “Are you handing over the girl, or am I going to start firing off? Pick one fox.”

“You gonna shoot me with a gun again?”

Almira flicked the grass wand as if it were a gun. “BLAHBERTGILLIOUS!”

A bright beam of shot out the end of the gar towards the fox, sending snow swirling. It struck the god, sending it hurling until it came crashing against the slope wall. Trapping the fox in ice and snow.

Almira tried to remove the vines off Bonnie, but her knife would not cut the living handcuffs. Bonnie struggled to wiggle out, but they were attached firmly. They heard the fox using his fire breath to escape the snow.

“Leave me! You shouldn’t get hurt because of me,” Bonnie said.

She would not. Almira picked the child up over her shoulders and hurried away as fast as she could. The two did not get far. Before they could gain distance, they heard heavy panting from something watching them. The fire breathing of the fox grew louder, he would find a way to break through at any moment.

“BLAHBERTGILLIOUS!”

The shot rang out at the bear, hitting it in the chest. Killing it. It fell back on top of the fox, who had heated his way out only to be hit by the bear. This gave Almira time to tuck into the forest. Where she and the child would wait in silence for hours. Until it they were sure that they were alone.

“I told you to leave,” Bonnie said, breaking the silence. Almira, still carrying her, began to walk softly.

“No. I can’t. I’ve seen the ocean. We are going there to live. We had a deal. And if we die? Our reservations in hell set.”

“There is no way that is going to happen. Things can’t be that for us. The fox is toying with us. He will not be for long.”

“You are going to help me understand this magic. We are going back to your family’s camp. And we are studying book we can until we find a way to either kill or trap that god.”

“We can’t trap him in another stone.” Bonnie said. “The vessel is too easy to break.”

“We are going to find another way. Damn the cost.”

Episode Four: Galdorian

Snuffercycle Death Camp

“Are you sure you have the spell names down correctly for the soul bind?” Bonnie asked, not looking at Almira. She was knelling at the graves of the family the two of them had dug.

“I thought it didn’t matter what you said to activate the magic as long as your communication to the plant was strong enough.”

Bonnie nodded. “Yes. But the fox isn’t going to let us sit around for these to spells to work. Everything has to be lightning fast.”

“I need you to prepare for the worst,” said Almira closing a book. “We don’t stand a chance against a god.”

“It’s not the first time I’ve almost not made it out alive with you. You spent a lot of time reading volume thirteen. Promise me you will never use anything you read in that book.”

Almira ignored her. She packed as many books as she could into her pack. “Do you want to know my greatest

fear? It's getting old and die. In a few hours, I won't have to worry about that."

"Should we really carry so much?" Bonnie asked, placing her pack on her back. "Fox's aren't known for being slow."

"We'll need all the help we can get."

The snow began to fall heavier in the mist. The newly formed geyser has fogged up the mountain for miles. They both watched the flurry of flakes get swept away in the wind.

"Well," Almira asked. "Anything you want to say before we give death the stink eye?"

"Tell me what seeing the ocean and the land was like. Since. It we might not ever get there."

"If I didn't know any better, I'd say it's straight out of a fairy tale."

"I don't like fairy tales." Bonnie said. "They always end up gruesome. The one's I've read anyways."

In the distance, a pillar of smoke rose. Dark enough to be seen in the storm. Almira cursed and hurried towards the disturbance.

“That’s the sinkhole.” Almira shouted, “The fox has found the plants!”



On top of Sinkhole

Standing on the stone rim of the cavern, they looked down on the rising flames. The trees and everything on the forest floor burned so badly that the surrounding air was hard to breathe.

“Why didn’t we come up with a backup plan?” Almira asked.

“It was the only chance we had.”

Almira unholstered the grass wand and pointed to the fire below. “Blabertdillouis”.

A new geyser shot up into the sky. It’s water falling back down that coated the fire in moisture.

“Some of the spells might still work. Hurry! We can still get the drop on the fox.”

Something behind them exploded. They turned to see confetti falling in the fog. Several more charges of firecrackers went off, sending Almira and Bonnie stepping back towards the sinkhole.

“Surprise! Guess who!” the fox said, appearing in front of them. He sat cross-legged, floating in the air as if he were meditating. “You know what your problem is? Want. You always wanting something you can’t have. As if that will bring paradise upon you. It’s an endless chase. If you don’t want anything, you wouldn’t have any problems. The gods gave you a little magic for the entertainment, and everyone starts using their gifts in messed up ways. Cause you want it.”

The two had nowhere to run. The fox had boxed them in. The women drew their wands.

“Would you like to keep running? How about you swim butterfly style across the sinkhole? I rather find funny that for once the fox is hunting the hunters. I have a job to do, but I might as well enjoy it.”

The pit behind them turned to water. The still pool reflected an odd white glow. Almira noticed something strange, however. At the right angle, she could see in the reflection the face of the fox.

“Get ready. Get set. Swim!” the fox yelled.

Bonnie turned and leapt towards the pool.

“Wait!” Almira yelled. She turned and grabbed her, but it

was too late. She had stopped her from plummeting into the pit, but not yet from falling in. She gritted her teeth and used her feet as anchors as a confused Bonnie began to realise there was no water. It was an illusion.

[Fox laughter]

Almira could feel her ribs cracking as she pulled on the girl. But she could hold on no longer. She could only watch as Bonnie's grip loosened around her fingers. The girl fell down the pit like a rock. Until she reached the bottom, hitting the water so hard that its sound caused a massive shelf of snow to crash down into the cave.

"If a girl falls in a forest, and no one is around, does she make a sound? Wait, I might have that mixed up with something else." The fox asked.

Almira dived into the pile of snow that led down into the pit. But the fox took hold of her pants as she did. Causing her to let go out her grass wand, which sailed away in front of her.

The fox climbed up to her as they slid down the icy slope, gaining speed. She tried to grab the god and toss him off her, but his claws and teeth were too sharp. He bit into her as they wrestled. She screamed out as his attacks were too strong to defend against.

“I warned you that you would regret releasing me from that stone!”

“You’re about to be trapped inside something much stronger than a soul!” Almira yelled.

“Stop,” the fox mocked. “You’re making my cheeks hurt from laughing so much!”

They reached the bottom, slamming into a pile of snow against the pit wall. Almira hit the stone so hard on her left side that she could not lift her arm. She lay hurt and wounded. The fox circled her, its laughter echoing.

“Well, my special friend. Mission accomplished! Except you failed to put me back into the stone. That’s okay. You tried right? It’s okay that you suck at everything you do. Okay, you go night night now. Good bye.”

The fox slowly drew in a deep breath and stood over her. She was not afraid. She stared the fox in its eyes. Waiting for the end. Until she noticed something. Something green sticking out of the snow.

Grass. The same kind her wand had been made of. She grabbed it and snapped it off. She pointed it at the fox, who released a blast of fire from his mouth. She yelled while being burned. “Solusmarktusbabraus-MYSELF!”

The fox stopped, it's mouth dropped. "Yourself?!! You can't...! NOO!"

The fox god began to melt. He tried to run, but his body had turned to ooze. The mess and essence of the fox lifted into the air and shot towards Almira's grass wand before travelling into her body. The earth shook, and the snow stopped. The clouds cleared, and the moon was no longer blood red. In the place where the fox had once been, was now a stone statue of a fox. Its face stuck in a look of horror.

But the stone was not like the charm Almira had found. The stone was a placeholder for a soul that has been sent to the void. A void big enough to hold a god. This stone could not be broken. For the soul bond that Almira created in that moment was not with any stone. She had bonded the fox to her own soul.

Almira pulled Bonnie from the slushy, frozen river. But it was too late. There were no signs of life in her. She spoke the spell the girl had spoken to save her. But no help came. This was because there was no help that could be given.

Almira searched the snow frantically. Until she found her pack. She started to read everything she could in the

Snuffercylde book of death plants. Volume 13.

She jabbed her right finger at an entry. Then frowned sharply at the steps listed in order to cast the spell. That is when she learned the cost of bringing a person back from the dead. A person must be fertilized into the garden for the Skeltor spell to work. She would need to fulfil that requirement in order to bring her back.



Mountain Chasm. Ten minutes later.

She watched as J.K Diecknine headed towards the rising smoke. Just as the sun had faded on the horizon. Almira crept up behind him, holding a large branch. With the only arm she had left, she raised it to strike him on the back of the head.

But she didn't. She couldn't.

Instead, she dropped the boulder, causing Diecknine to turn around. She hung her head. That was a road she had walked before. Which had led her to where she was.

“I’m not a murderer.”

“I suppose that’s good to hear,” Diecknine quipped. “But why? You know I have to bring you in front of the town

elders. And charge all you Snuffercyldes with using illegal magic. Why would you come looking for me?”

“Bonnie is dead. And I bounded the fox to my soul.”

“How long ago?” he asked.

She told him.

“Did she have anything in her hands?”

“I didn’t check,” she said. “Why would...”

“Bring me to her. Quick! There is still time!”



Sink Hole

Diecknine unrolled Bonnie’s icy fingers. She was holding a blue, glowing stone. The man took it and showed it to Almira. He handed it to her.

“If you want her to wake up, break this,” he said.

The woman ran to the stone wall and smashed it as hard as she could. The glow floated from within the stone and flew over to the girl.

Bonnie took a long, large breath. The girl looked around, confused.

“Guess what?” Almira said, holding her head up for better airflow. “You were wrong. You are going to see the ocean after all. After we get there, I am going to destroy you at cards.”

A large hawk swooped down into the hole and landed next to Diecknine. The man took a folded note from its claws. He unfolded and read it.

“They are sending a team. We are to stay put. Then you will both be placed on trial,” Diecknine told them. “Stay here. I am going to wait at the top. I’d be afraid of you running, but you both are thin as ghosts. You know what will happen if you try to escape.”

“What did you do?” Almira asked Bonnie. “What is the stone...”

“I was able to grab a piece of cliff. I then put my soul into it added a reviving blossom for a kick. It’s a Snuffercylde breed. Was. We only had one. And I used it. What happened to the fox?”

Almira turned her head away. She pointed to the fox stone near them. Bonnie could not look at the fox’s expression for long.

“I don’t understand.” Bonnie said. “You have to root the

soul you are transferring into something. How did you... no. You didn't..."

"I thought it would destroy both of us. Why am I still here?"

"You didn't read the end of volume thirteen." Bonnie said. "What you have done. Is taboo. Theorized as a yo-yo wizard. The fox is in the void while you are here. If you were to die, the fox would return. Sending you to the void. There can only be one in the world."

"So when I die of old age, the fox comes back?" Almira asked.

"No one has ever seen it happen."

"So the village can't burn me at the stake without the fox coming back to burn everyone?"

"Yes," Bonnie said.

"I don't think we are getting sent to the stakes." Almira said.



Whisper Settlement

"Prisoners, please rise." Diecknine said.

Almira and Bonnie did as they were asked. They were in a log building still being added to. This permanent structure would become the town's first courthouse in the years to come. But in that moment the space was rough but alright for having been built in a hurry.

“We have decided as a council not to charge you under any of the too numerous to code civil code 46 violations. You will both be allowed to keep your stakes of land. With the note that there are rumours that the government might be offering the same land to new pioneers. As a village, we will work through that complication. However. It is by full agreement of every member here that all the Snuffercylde family will be banned from any and all village events, holidays and festivals.”

“NO!” Bonnie shouted.

“This included any of your offspring,” Diecknine went on. “The magic schools will also never be allowed to accept a Snuffercylde. For we have seen the kind of danger the family is capable of. The family will be allowed to shop in town for normal supplies. You will not however be permitted to purchase any magic plants and or other Galdorian items.”

“The village has never been this cruel in our history. You are banishing us from the settlement!”

“Yes,” Diecknine said truthfully. “Under the circumstances, we feel this is the best for everyone. The plants in the cavern will be destroyed. Release them.”

Almira and Bonnie were guided out of the room and onto the street. There they stood with a view of the sea. Almira breathed in the seaweed smelling air and let out a sigh. The ocean mist surrounded them and the other villagers working on places where they could someday trade with others who had travelled the long, torturous trail.

“That cavern is too big for them to find everything.” Almira said. “I think someday we will go back. There could be miles and miles of your family’s legacy growing in any place where the sun shines.”

Bonnie shrugged and smiled. “We have our land. Aunt Almira. I’m going to need your help to get a farm running.”

“I am going to learn to build something for our garden. Maybe inside a castle. If I can learn to build one of those. If I ever find the time.”



And that is how Snuffercyde Tower was built over the next couple hundred years off the shore of Whisper's Bay. Where Almira's stake to the land includes a small rock structure large enough to be considered an island. Far enough away for anyone to see what the two were growing. And for the first time since Almira was fourteen, she felt like she had a life again. That was at first.

Until over the years her skin did not change, and her hair did not grey. Bonnie, however, grew up and had a family of her own. Aging normally. Each of whom always thought fondly of Aunt Almira. The woman who always made sure everyone ate first and was always a source of advice.

The kids grew up and moved out. First Bonnie's husband passed away of old age. Not too long after, Bonnie was laid to rest in the family garden. With the remains of her family that were transported there when the castle construction began.

Almira was alone again. Unaged. Unchanged. Other than some might say, she looked weathered. In the years after, Almira kept to herself on her land. Waiting for death to come knocking once again. In fear that the fox would be released and she be sent to the void. However,

this did not happen.



Whisper's Bay. Snufferclyde Tower Garden 2017.

“This is the place, Taylor!” A teenage girl whispered to her friend. “The perfect place to pull our senior prank. This lady has lived here forever, we can do this, get our degrees and get the dispensary license. So we can start figuring out a cure for the curse. Amanda said this would be the perfect place!”

The other girl shined her flashlight deeper into the garden. Her mouth was hung open, as if she had seen a murderous ghost approaching.

The girl cursed. “No! This is bad, we need to get out of here, Braylynn.”

“Relax, we can handle an old lady. Peacefully.”

The girls heard a gun cock nearby. A woman in a cowboy hat approached them. Wearing clothes that looked like she had come from filming a western.

“This gun still fires. Do you want to see? Or do you kids want to get out of my garden?” Almira said.

“We’re so sorry!” The one named Taylor shouted. “My friend is a moron with very understanding of...!”

“Yeah?” the woman said, lowering the gun. “Surprise. I know who you are. Those cats you see in town? Those are ours. The snuffercylde spies tell me everything. And worst of all, I know one of you is secretly a whitlock.”

“Who told you?” One asked.

“That is my concern.” Almira said. “Although I have many friends. Your secrets are safe with me. Your trespassing however? Is not.”

The two teenagers backed away. “We are leaving. We are so sorry. Your spell garden is so beautiful I want to cry.”

“Be still a moment,” Almira said approaching them. “For I have heard other things. The one called Taylor. Kimama. You have heard the tale of the fox stone curse? And you are in company of one who has cast the yo-yo bound on another?”

“No,” One teen said.

“It is unwise to lie to a...” Almira stopped. And then laughed. The two girls looked at her like she had lost her mind. “... to lie to a fox. It’s an old joke. I know you are considering using the yo-yo curse as you kids are calling

it these days. For a very good reason. It is noble. And kind. But you should not do it. Some things are meant to happen. Bending the universe to your submission feels so easy. But it's not. Humans really do like getting into cycles. Do not perform the spell. Let nature, how unfair may it be, take its cruel course."

"I make my own decisions," the girl said.

"Good," Almira said. "I don't like people telling me what to do either. But the burden you must bear does not end."

"No offense," said the girl. "But by the size of this tower here, I don't think you know what a burden even is. I can't let the girl die."

"You have been warned," Almira said. She drew her gun and raised it into the air. "Now. Get out of my garden or I'll start shooting. I'll use my spells after I'm out of bullets. That can take all night, so I reckon you better start running now."

The girls scrambled towards where they have entered from the crack in the tower. The woman watched them as they panicked and shouted.

"Stupid kids." The woman said. "Bet they don't even

know how to bake cornbread from scratch.”

From there she went on living. Until the day she is somehow killed. Then. And only then shall the fox ever return.

THE END.